

LESSON 7

NAVIGATING WEAK ROOTS: I-ALAPH, I-YODH, AND III-YODH VERBS

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSONS 5–6

Quick Summary In Lessons 5 and 6, we expanded our vocabulary exponentially by learning how Semitic roots generate new meanings through derived stems. The **Aphel** stem (prefix

ʾA –

) generates causative verbs (e.g., God

ʾAHYĪ

“gave life”). The **Paael** stem (doubled middle radical) generates intensive or factitive verbs (e.g.,

QADDAŠ

“he made holy”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill (*Answers in Section 9*) 1. What stem does a verb belonging to the pattern ʾaCCeC belong to (e.g., ʾaqreb)? 2. What consonant prefix marks the active participle of *all* derived stems (Aphel, Paael, etc.)? 3. Translate: *Alāhā ʾaglī šrārā*. 4. If *q-d-š* in *Peal* means “to be holy”, what does it mean in *Paael* (*qaddaš*)? 5. How would you recognize a *Paael* participle versus a *Peal* participle?

SECTION 2: THE WEAK VERB CHALLENGE — OVERVIEW

Until now, we have mostly dealt with “strong” roots (like *k-t-b* or *š-b-q*), where all three consonants boldly assert themselves in every conjugation. However, some of the most common verbs in human language—to say, to be, to know, to give, to come—are “weak”. This means one of their three root consonants is a “weak letter” (Alaph, Waw, or Yodh), which tends to assimilate, drop out entirely, or turn into a vowel depending on the surrounding sounds.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: Weak Consonants Weak verbs are the bane of every Semitic language student, but they follow highly predictable phonetic rules. * **Hebrew:** I-Guttural (אָמַר *ʾāmar* = he said); I-Yod (יָדָע *yādaʿ* = he knew); Lamed-He/Yod (בָּנָה *bānāh* = he built). * **Arabic:** Hollow verbs (قَالَ *qāla* = he said); Defective/Final Weak (رَمَى *ramā* = he threw). * **Syriac:** - **I-Alaph:** Root ʾ-*m-r* (to say) → ʾemar (not ʾamar). - **I-Yodh:** Root *y-d-* (to know) → īdaʿ (Yodh acts like an *i* vowel). - **III-Yodh:** Root *h-z-y* (to see) → hzā (the Yodh drops out, leaving an *ā* vowel).

SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY OF WEAK ROOTS (PEAL PERFECT)

Despite the spelling changes, weak verbs function syntactically exactly like strong verbs: VSO word order, taking suffixes, and forming the spine of clauses.

1. I-Alaph Verbs (First consonant is Alaph) The most famous is ʾ-*m-r* (“to say”). In the Peal perfect 3rd masc singular, the vowel shifts to *e*: * ʾemar (he said), rather than ʾamar. * ʾemret (I said), rather than ʾamret.

2. I-Yodh Verbs (First consonant is Yodh) Very common verbs like *y-d-* (to know) and *y-t-b* (to sit). The initial *y* fuses with the preceding invisible glottal stop to form an *ī* vowel. * *y-d-* → īdaʿ (he knew). * *y-t-b* → īteb (he sat). *Note: The verb y-h-b (to give) is highly irregular and behaves like a strong verb without an internal vowel: yahb (he gave).*

3. III-Yodh Verbs (Third consonant is Yodh) Verbs ending in Yodh (like *h-z-y*, *b-n-y*, *h-y-y*). The Yodh falls away in the 3rd masc singular, leaving a final *ā* vowel. In other persons, the Yodh can reappear as heavily vocalized endings. * *h-z-y* (to see) → hzā (he saw) [looks like a 2-consonant word]. * *h-z-y* + -et (I saw) → hzēt (the *ay* contracts to *ē*). * *h-z-y* + -ū (They saw) → hzaw (the *ay-ū* contracts to *aw*).

SECTION 4: III-YODH PARADIGM (ROOT: ܚ-ܙ-ܝ "TO SEE")

Because III-Yodh verbs lose their third consonant so frequently, memorizing their exact endings is essential.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	NOTES
3 m.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzā	he saw	Ends in <i>ā</i> (Alaph)
3 f.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzāt	she saw	Ends in <i>āt</i>
2 m.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzayt	you (m) saw	Yodh reappears, <i>ay</i> diphthong
2 f.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzaytī	you (f) saw	Yodh reappears
1 c.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzēt	I saw	Yodh contracts with <i>et</i> to <i>ēt</i>
3 m.pl.	ܠܐ	ḥzaw	they (m) saw	<i>w</i> makes <i>aw</i> diphthong
3 f.pl.	ܠܐ	ḥzay	they (f) saw	<i>y</i> makes <i>ay</i> diphthong
1 c.pl.	ܠܐ	ḥzayn	we saw	<i>ay</i> diphthong

SECTION 5: THE HIGHLY IRREGULAR VERBS ' -T-Y AND H-W-Y

Two of the most common verbs in Syriac are doubly weak and highly irregular. 1. ' -t-y (to come): I-Alaph AND III-Yodh. * 3 m.s: 'etā (he came). * 1 c.s: 'etēt (I came). * 3 m.pl: 'etaw (they came). 2. h-w-y (to be/become): Used as an auxiliary verb, or to mean "it happened". III-Yodh. * 3 m.s: hwā (he was / it happened). * 1 c.s: hwēt (I was). * 3 m.pl: hwaw (they were).

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (WEAK VERBS & COURT TERMS)

ROOT	PEAL PERFECT 3M.S.	MEANING	CLASSIFICATION
י.פ.ר	'emar (עמר)	to say	I-Alaph
א.א.ל	'ekal (אכל)	to eat	I-Alaph
א.א.ל	'ezal (עזל)	to go	I-Alaph
י.ד.ע	īda ' (ידע)	to know	I-Yodh
י.ד.ב	īteb (יטב)	to sit	I-Yodh
י.ד.נ	yahb (יחב)	to give	I-Yodh (Irregular)
י.י.ח	ḥzā (יחז)	to see	III-Yodh
ק.ר.א	qrā (קרא)	to call / read	III-Alaph (behaves like III-Yodh)
י.ב.נ	bnā (בנה)	to build	III-Yodh
י.י.ח	ḥyā (יחיה)	to live	III-Yodh
י.א.ע	'etā (יעה)	to come	I-Alaph & III-Yodh
י.ח.ו	hwā (יחוו)	to be/become	III-Yodh
(Noun)	רעגז (rūgzā)	anger/wrath	Emotion abstract
(Noun)	חזמן (hemzman)	word / report	Court term

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 7

The Summons Narrative *note: Pay attention to the massive use of weak roots—*
'emar (said), 'ezal (went), īda ' (knew), hwā (was/became), ḥzaw (they saw),
'etā (came).

Sentence 1 כה אמר יוחנן מלתא דאלאה, 'ezalū qašišē l-wāt malkā. kad
kad 'emar Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā, 'ezalū qašišē l-wāt malkā. kad
(when) 'emar (said) Yūḥannan (John) meltā (the-word) d-Alāhā (of-
God), 'ezalū (went) qašišē (the-elders/guards) l-wāt (to-the-presence-of)
malkā (the-king). → When Yukhannan said the word of God, the guards
went to the king.

Sentence 2 רָאָה מָה הָיָה בְּתַרְאָה 'āmṛīn l-eh:

yād 'īn-ḥnan mā hwā b-tar 'ā! 'āmṛīn (they-[are]-saying) l-eh (to-him):

yād 'īn (knowing) -ḥnan (are-we) mā (what) hwā (happened/was) b-

tar 'ā (in-the-gate)! → They say to him: “We know what happened at the gate!”

Sentence 3 רָאָה מָה הָיָה בְּתַרְאָה ḥzayn gabrā, w- 'emar

meltā bīštā. ḥzayn (we-saw) gabrā (a-man), w- 'emar (and-said) meltā (a-

word) bīštā (evil-[f]). → “We saw a man, and he said an evil word.”

Sentence 4 הָיָה מֶלֶךְ רָגִיז מְאֹד מָה הָיָה hwā hāšā malkā ragīz ṭāb. hwā

(became/was) hāšā (now) malkā (the-king) ragīz (angry) ṭāb (greatly/

very). → Now the king was very angry.

Sentence 5 רָאָה מָה הָיָה בְּתַרְאָה 'emar malkā l-

qašīšē: 'aytāw-hy l-harkā! 'emar (said) malkā (the-king) l-qašīšē (to-the-

guards): 'aytāw-hy (let-them-bring-him [Aphel imperative]) l-harkā (to-

here)! → The king said to the guards: “Bring him here!”

Sentence 6 הָיָה מֶלֶךְ קְדָם יוֹחָנָן w- 'etā Yūḥannan qdām malkā. w-

'etā (and-came) Yūḥannan (John) qdām (before) malkā (the-king). →

And Yukhannan came before the king.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification Identify the root and grammatical

form of these weak verbs: 1. הָיָה (ḥzēt) 2. רָאָה ('emarū) 3. רָאָה

('etā) 4. יָבֹהֵ (yahbū)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill Conjugate the root ' -m -r (to say) in the Peal

perfect for: 1. I said 2. We said 3. You (m.sg) said 4. They (m.pl) said

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English) Translate the following past narrative clauses involving weak verbs. 1. ʾEmarū qašīšē meltā. 2. Ḥzayn nūhrā d-Alāhā b-tar ʾā. 3. W-īda ʾ malkā rūgzā (wrath). 4. Hwaw b-ʾar ʾā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac) Render the following narrative sentences into Syriac transliteration. (Remember VSO order). 1. The evil king saw (ḥzā) the man. 2. We came (ʾetayn) to the kingdom. 3. I gave (yahbet) the garment to the guard (qašīšā). 4. John knew (īda ʾ) the word of God.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension Re-read Section 7 and answer: 1. Who did the guards go to? 2. What do the guards claim they saw and heard? 3. How did the king react to the news?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up 1. Aphel. (Causative). 2. *Mīm* (m-). e.g., *ma ʾleb*, *mqaddeš*. 3. God revealed the truth. 4. To make holy / to sanctify. 5. The vowel pattern: *mqaddeš* (Paael) vs *kāteb* (Peal). The Peal has no *m*- prefix in the active participle.

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification 1. Root: *ḥ-z-y*. Form: Peal perfect, 1 c.sg (I saw). 2. Root: ʾ-m-r. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They said). 3. Root: ʾ-t-y. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.sg (He came). 4. Root: *y-h-b*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They gave).

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill 1. ʾemret 2. ʾemran 3. ʾemart 4. ʾemarū

Exercise 3: Translation Drill 1. The guards said a word. 2. We saw the light of God in the gate. 3. And the king knew wrath. 4. They were in the earth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill 1. Ḥzā malkā bīšā l-gabrā. (*l-* marks direct object). 2. 'Etain l-malkūttā. 3. Yahbet lbūšā l-qašīšā. 4. Īda ' Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension 1. To the king. 2. A man who said an evil word. 3. He became very angry (*ragīz ṭāb*) and demanded the man be brought to him.

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

WEAK VERB SHIFT SUMMARY

CLASS	ROOT	SHIFT RULE	3 M.SG EXAMPLE	1 C.SG EXAMPLE
I-Alaph	'-m-r	First vowel becomes <i>e</i>	'emar (he said)	'emret (I said)
I-Yodh	y-d-'	Initial Yodh + stop → <i>ī</i>	īda' (he knew)	īd'et (I knew)
III-Yodh	ḥ-z-y	Yodh drops, ends in <i>ā</i> in 3ms	ḥzā (he saw)	ḥzēt (I saw)
Double Weak	'-t-y	Follows both rules	'etā (he came)	'etēt (I came)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on derived nouns (abstract and concrete) from weak roots and related weak-root vocabulary.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
አሁን	'ūmūttā	f. noun	oneness, unity	from weak root '-w-m
አሁን	dāmūttā	f. noun	likeness, image	from root d-m- y (to be like)
አሁን	ḥazūttā	f. noun	vision, sight	from III-Yodh root ḥ-z-y
አሁን	bənūttā	f. noun	building, structure	from III-Yodh root b-n-y
አሁን	'əlūttā	f. noun	ascent, exaltation	from I-Alaph root ' -l-y
አሁን	qərūttā	f. noun	calling, vocation	from III-Alaph/ Yodh root q-r- '
አሁን	'awdərānā	m. noun	help, aid	from root ' -d-r
አሁን	yāzəpā	m. noun	beauty, form	from root y-z-p
አሁን	ḥəbīyūnā	m. noun	gift, offering	from I-Yodh root y-h-b
አሁን	'ətyānūttā	f. noun	coming, arrival	from weak root '-t-y
አሁን	ḥəwīyūttā	f. noun	being, existence	from III-Yodh root h-w-y
አሁን	'ālmūttā	f. noun	worldliness, temporality	from weak root '-l-m
አሁን	dūqā	m. noun	bench, throne	from weak root d-w-q
አሁን	gūrā	m. noun	dwelling, cave	from weak root g-w-r
አሁን	ṭūprā	m. noun	appearance, form	from weak root ṭ-w-p-r
አሁን	qūmā	m. noun	standing, resurrection	from I-Alaph/ Yodh root q-y- m
አሁን	napī 'ā	m. noun	seer, prophet	from I-Alaph root n-p- '
አሁን	'ōnā	m. noun	strength, power	from weak root '-w-n

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
ረዕዓዊ	šūwəddā	m. noun	testimony, witness	from weak root š-w-d
ረዕዓዊ	rūmūttā	f. noun	highness, exaltation	from weak root r-w-m
ረዕዓ	qərā	m. noun	cold	from weak root q-r-ʾ
ረዕዓ	ḥelmā	m. noun	dream	from weak root ḥ-l-m
ረዕዓ	dūsā	m. noun	trampling, subjugation	from weak root d-w-s
ረዕዓ	ləlūttā	f. noun	lamenting, wailing	from weak root l-l-y
ረዕዓ	pūrā	m. noun	fruit	from weak root p-w-r
ረዕዓ	ʾūqqānā	m. noun	knot, binding	from weak root ʾ-q-d
ረዕዓ	šəlyānā	m. noun	peace, wholeness	from weak root š-l-y
ረዕዓዊ	ʾətwūttā	f. noun	sign, omen	from weak root ʾ-t-w
ረዕዓ	nūttā	f. noun	rest, dwelling	from weak root n-w-t
ረዕዓዊ	wayrūttā	f. noun	shame, disgrace	from weak root w-y-r